not. Some rabbis condemned that text as secular love poetry, while Rabbi Akiva (d. 135 CE) defended it as the divinely inspired creation of King Solomon. Akiva famously said that 'the Song of Songs is the Holy of Holies'.[22] By the end of the second century CE widespread consensus was apparently reached among Jewish rabbis about which texts were part of the biblical canon and which were not, but debates about this matter, and about the precise wordings, spelling and pronunciation of each text, were not finally resolved until the Masoretic era (seventh to tenth centuries CE).[23]

This process of canonisation decided that Genesis was the word of Jehovah, but the book of Enoch, the Life of Adam and Eve and the Testament of Abraham were human fabrications.[24] The Psalms of King David were canonised (minus psalms 151–55), but the Psalms of King Solomon were not. The book of Malachi got the seal of approval; the book of Baruch did not. Chronicles, yes; Maccabees, no.

Interestingly, some books mentioned in the Bible itself failed to get into the canon. For example, the books of Joshua and Samuel both refer to a very ancient sacred text known as the book of Jasher (Joshua 10:13, 2 Samuel 1:18). The book of Numbers refers to 'the Book of the Wars of the Lord' (Numbers 21:14). And when 2 Chronicles surveys the reign of King Solomon, it concludes by saying that 'the rest of the acts of Solomon, first and last, are written in the chronicles of Nathan the prophet, and in the prophecy of Ahijah the Shilonite, and in the visions of Iddo the seer' (2 Chronicles 9:29). The books of Iddo, Ahijah and Nathan, as well as the books of Jasher and the Wars of the Lord, aren't in the canonical Bible. Apparently, they were not excluded on purpose; they just got lost.[25]

After the canon was sealed, most Jews gradually forgot the role of human institutions in the messy process of compiling the Bible. Jewish Orthodoxy maintained that God personally handed down to Moses at Mount Sinai the entire first part of the Bible, the Torah. Many rabbis further argued that God created the Torah at the very dawn of time so that even biblical characters who lived before Moses – like Noah and Adam – read and studied it.[26] The other parts of the Bible also came to be seen as a divinely created or divinely inspired text, totally different from ordinary human compilations. Once the holy book was sealed, it was hoped that Jews now had direct access to Jehovah's exact words, which no fallible human or corrupt institution could erase or alter.